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Myth and Politics: A Response to Robert Ellwood

IN HIS CAREFUL and balanced review of Bruce Lincoln's *Theorizing Myth* and my *Theorizing about Myth*, Robert Ellwood raises the key question of the political nature of myth. Ellwood shares with Lincoln the conviction that myth is political, as the title of Ellwood's own recent book, *The Politics of Myth* (1999), evinces. I part company with both Ellwood and Lincoln on this point. For me, some theories of myth are entirely apolitical. A theory could loosely be labeled political because the theorist holds political opinions but could tightly be so labeled because the theory itself views myth as a political vehicle. In deeming myth political, Ellwood shifts from one sense of political to another, though recognizing the shift. He considers the political opinions of William Jones, Nietzsche, Dumézil, Eliade, and Campbell but also asks "to what extent can the political views—and sins—of a mythological scholar . . . be said to stain all the scholar's work?" (2001: 679).

In my own efforts at organizing the array of theories of myth, I have distinguished between rationalist and romantic approaches. In *Work on Myth* Hans Blumenberg makes a similar distinction. Ellwood, too, uses this distinction but always emphasizes that both rationalists and romantics politicize myth, albeit in different ways: "Let us look again at Segal's division of myth interpretation into the rationalist and the romantic styles. It is important to realize that both can have baleful consequences as justifications for colonialism and racist nationalism" (2001: 680).

For rationalists, myth is the wholly "primitive" counterpart to science, which is exclusively modern. Myth and science are not merely redundant but outright incompatible: myth invokes the wills of gods to account for events in the world; science appeals to impersonal processes like those of

atoms. Because both purport to give direct accounts of events, one cannot stack a mythological account atop a scientific one. The rain god does not manipulate meteorological processes but, say, collects buckets of water and dumps them on a chosen spot. For rationalists, there can be no “modern myths,” and the phrase is self-contradictory. Any lingering myths are sheer relics. For Ellwood (see 1999: 171) as well as for me, the epitome of a rationalist is the Victorian anthropologist Edward Tylor, to whom I devote the first chapter of my book.

Just what is political about a rationalist approach to myth? According to Ellwood, myths for rationalists “represent premodern, prescientific ways of looking at the world that have now been superseded”; science has “emancipated” us from “the shackles of ignorance, superstition, and despotism” (2001: 680). Progress means not only the replacement of personal explanations of the world by impersonal ones but also the replacement of particularistic explanations by generalizations: “This knowledge that emancipates is found through the generalized, abstract, rational ways of thinking characteristic of science and social science. . . . [T]he particular is subordinated to the abstract category; . . . the local submits to the universal” (Ellwood 2001: 680–681).

How fully does this characterization of rationalism fit Tylor? While Tylor clearly associates myth with primitives and associates science with moderns, the similarities rather than the differences between myth and science grab him. Like science, myth arises from observation and hypothesis. Myth is consummately rational, even if false. Primitives concoct myth rather than science only because they take the first explanation at hand: they analogize from their own behavior to invent humanlike agents to account for events in the world. Primitives are uncritical but hardly “superstitious.” Myths “rest upon a broad philosophy of nature, early and crude indeed, but thoughtful, consistent, and quite really and seriously meant” (Tylor: vol. 1, 285). Primitives harbor the same intellectual curiosity as moderns (see Tylor: vol. 1, 368–369). Not to emotion but “to the human intellect” “may be assigned the origin and first development of myth” (Tylor: vol. 1, 284).

For Tylor, myth is as generalizable as science: whenever it rains, the same god has decided to send rain and for the same reason. Each kind of event in the world may be attributed to a different god with a different myth, but taken collectively myths offer a uniform account of all physical events. Each culture may have its own, “local” mythology, but Tylor’s insistence on a comparative approach “makes it possible to trace in mythology [worldwide] the operation of imaginative processes recurring with the evident regularity of mental law” (vol. 1, 282). Myths are similar because imagination is tethered to reason. Asks Tylor rhetorically, “What would

be popularly [but incorrectly] thought more indefinite and uncontrolled than the products of the imagination, in myths and fables?" (vol. 1, 18).

Here Tylor anticipates Claude Lévi-Strauss, the grandest twentieth-century reviver of a rationalist approach to myth. Like Tylor, Lévi-Strauss observes that although "it would seem that in the course of a myth anything is likely to happen," in fact "this apparent arbitrariness is belied by the astounding similarity between myths collected in widely different regions" (1965: 83). For both Tylor and Lévi-Strauss, the demonstration of uniformity in myth, the seemingly least orderly of artifacts, proves that not only it but also its primitive creators are scrupulously rational. Lévi-Strauss ventures beyond Tylor to argue that mythic thinking is itself scientific, simply the science of the concrete. Abstractions get expressed *through* the concrete (see Lévi-Strauss 1966: chap. 1).

Ellwood—or Lincoln—could rightly reply that for all of Tylor's respect for myth, it remains for him wholly primitive, inferior to science, incompatible with science, and superseded by science. Tylor may not be contemptuous, but he is patronizing. To fill in a line of his already quoted in part, "to the human intellect *in its early childlike state* may be assigned the origin and first development of myth" (vol. 1, 284, emphasis added). Paternalism, it could be argued, provides sufficient "justifications for colonialism and racist nationalism."

In response, I would simply note that for Tylor myth comes very close to science, so close that it is not even easy to figure out why it fails to be scientific (see Segal 1999: 7–10). Certainly Tylor does not regard primitives as incapable of advancing beyond myth to science. Moreover, because there were no moderns until there was science, it can only be the last generation of primitives that created science. Juxtapose to Tylor his antirationalist critic Lucien Lévy-Bruhl, for whom primitives are driven by emotion rather than intellect, are incapable of recognizing even the law of noncontradiction, and use myth not to explain anything but to re-create the fading experience of mystical oneness with the world (see Lévy-Bruhl: chap. 9).

Furthermore, myth for Tylor is hopelessly apolitical. For it is almost entirely about the physical world. Myth explains why it rains, not why marriage exists. Myth is the counterpart to natural science, not to social science.

Some rationalist theorists do tie myth to politics. James Frazer, whom Ellwood (see 1999: 171), like me, also considers a leading rationalist, parallels intellectual change to political change. Magicians become kings and "gradually rise to wealth and power" (Frazer: 104). Priests succeed magicians and themselves become kings, initially merely human but eventually divine, and "no class of the community has benefited so much as kings by this belief in the possible incarnation of a god in human form" (Frazer:

105). Frazer even writes of “the great social revolution which thus begins with democracy and ends in despotism” (104). At the same time the key activity now is the killing and replacement of the king to ensure the health of the god of vegetation residing in the incumbent. Indeed, the chief event in the king’s reign is his death, which is undertaken for the sake of the community. The Frazerian Lord Raglan thus singles out the loss of the throne as the heart of his mythic pattern and pronounces the king heroic exactly because the king dies for the communal good. Myths celebrate the selfless heroism of past kings and inspire emulation (see Raglan: pt. 2). Still, myth for Raglan does not quite justify regicide, and for Frazer the subject matter of myth is the death and rebirth of the god of vegetation, not the killing and replacement of the king (see Segal 1999: 39–41, 130–134).

The theorist for whom myth *would* justify ritualistic regicide is Bronislaw Malinowski, but ironically Malinowski scorns the rationalist approach. For Malinowski, primitives have myth not in place of science but alongside science: “There is no doubt that even the lowest savage communities have the beginnings of science, however rudimentary” (34). Primitives use science, together with magic, both to explain and to control the physical world. They turn to myth when the world proves uncontrollable. Myths about natural phenomena such as floods supplement primitive science. They serve no political function. Myths about social phenomena such as rituals serve the incontestably political function of giving these phenomena, which are anything but unavoidable, a hoary origin and thereby the clout of tradition. But these myths run askew to science, not, as in rationalism, contrary to science.

Among rationalists, the theorist most keenly attuned to myth as political is Ernst Cassirer, mentioned by neither Ellwood nor Lincoln. On the one hand, Cassirer places myth, or mythic thinking, within his main forms of knowledge—science being another. While he takes unabashedly from Lévy-Bruhl the conception of myth as primitive, as emotion laden, and as projective, he claims to be breaking with Lévy-Bruhl in asserting that mythic thinking, rather than “prelogical,” has its own brand of logic and in asserting that mythic thinking, rather than inferior to science, is an autonomous brand of knowledge (see Cassirer 1955: 21). Myth so characterized can be studied philosophically.

On the other hand, Cassirer comes to see myth as not merely primitive but also modern. Now he turns to political myths, notably those of Nazism. Myth here amounts to ideology and very much fits Lincoln’s provocative definition of all myth as “ideology in narrative form.” Having previously concentrated on sublime, epistemological issues, Cassirer now turns to brute, social scientific ones: How do political myths take and keep hold? Having previously scorned Lévy-Bruhl’s supposed stress on

the irrationality of myth, Cassirer now embraces it: "In all critical moments of man's social life, the rational forces that resist the rise of the old mythical conceptions are no longer sure of themselves. In these moments the time for myth has come again" (1946: 280). Tying myth to magic and magic to a desperate effort to control the world—here the social, not the physical, world—Cassirer applies to modern myths Malinowski's analysis of primitive myths. Modern myths constitute an atavistic revival of, for Cassirer, primitivism.

Yet Cassirer still does not fit Ellwood's rationalist bill because, in deeming political myths irrational, he cuts them off from philosophy. Myth now is anything but a form of knowledge with a distinctive logic to be teased out. The marginalized role left philosophy is to challenge political myths: "It is beyond the power of philosophy to destroy the political myths. A myth . . . is impervious to rational arguments. . . . But philosophy can do us another important service. It can make us understand the adversary" (Cassirer 1946: 296).

To turn to the romantic theorists of myth, for them, myth, rather than merely primitive, is an eternal possession. Nothing can supersede it. Whereas for rationalists science better serves the explanatory *function* than myth, for romantics nothing duplicates the psychological or metaphysical *content* of myth. Whereas for rationalists science renders myth at once unnecessary and impossible for moderns, for romantics science and myth run askew, so that moderns can have and indeed must have myth. Whereas for rationalists the *function* served by myth may be indispensable, for romantics myth itself is indispensable to the serving of its function. Myth is revelatory. For me, and for Ellwood as well, the epitomes of a romantic approach to myth are C. G. Jung, Mircea Eliade, and Joseph Campbell. To the three of them Ellwood devotes his *Politics of Myth*.

As with rationalism, so with romanticism: What is political about this approach to myth? According to Ellwood, romanticism accords every race or nation "its own defining myth or 'myth cycle'": "One finds a rediscovery of founding myths and national heroes, an idealization of rural 'rootedness' located in peasants or pioneers, and a sense that the nation is not just a political entity but a spiritual reality as well" (2001: 682–683). Mythology serves the group, not the individual. This view might seem egalitarian, crediting the mythology of each culture with "still-valid messages from the timeless beginnings of humanity." But the mythology of one nation can be vaulted over others as that "of a superior people." Moreover, while some mythologies "were certainly brought into the service of legitimate independence movements and democratic reform" (Ellwood 2001: 682–683), others strove to revive a nondemocratic, idealized past. And outsiders could be targeted as aliens.

Ellwood maintains that Jung, Eliade, and Campbell, while conspicuously modern as academics, “can rightly be labeled antimodern,” emphasizing as they do “the illness of the modern world, for which they contended myth could serve as sovereign elixir” (2001: 681). At the same time Ellwood divides the romantic camp into political activists, of whom the *locus classicus* is indisputably Georges Sorel, and “contemplatives,” who in “gnostic” fashion sought escape from the flawed everyday world into “a dreamy escapist inner world” (2001: 684). Ellwood’s trio falls here.

How well does this characterization of romanticism fit the three? Undeniably, modernity for Jung represents the triumph of rationalism and science over religion and myth, and Jung urges the recovery of myth. But that recovery is *not* to be at the price of modernity. Jung sees himself as *part* of the modern world and proudly dubs himself a “scientist” of the mind. Modernity marks progress, not degeneration. The aim is to continue forward, not go backward. Psychologically, modernity represents the attainment of ego consciousness or consciousness of the external world. The development of ego consciousness has necessarily required a break with the primordial unconscious. The goal now is to return to the unconscious—but as a means to forging a balance between it and ego consciousness. Modern consciousness is more, not less, advanced than that of primitives, who psychologically, as for Tylor intellectually, are childlike: “These considerations tempt us to draw a parallel between the mythological thinking of ancient man and the similar thinking found in children, primitives, and in dreams” (Jung: 22–23). Modernity properly involves the withdrawal of primitive projections of gods onto the world.

The Jungian aim is to live in the outer as well as the inner world—with the two simply kept distinct. The outer world is not evil. It is just not the only world. As the editor of *The Gnostic Jung*, I would never downplay Jung’s fascination with gnosticism, but ironically Jung misinterprets gnosticism, as if it, like Jungian psychology, seeks to stay in the outer world rather than to escape from it (see Segal 1992b: 19–33). Because Jungian psychology stays tied to the outer world, it is open to political activism, as books like *Jung and Politics* and *The Political Psyche*, both cited by Ellwood, attest.

In *The Politics of Myth* Ellwood acknowledges some of these points. Commendably, he rejects the one-sided argument of Richard Noll in *The Jung Cult* and *The Aryan Christ* that Jung’s psychology derives from avowedly nationalistic, neopagan, antisemitic, anti-Semitic cults that arose at the turn of the century in German-speaking lands (see Ellwood 1999: 184 n. 36; Segal 1995). But Ellwood still links Jung to a reactionary impulse and in so doing surveys the evidence of Jung’s anti-Semitism.

What of the politics of myth? Jung does categorize mythologies along racial and national lines. But he categorizes myths in other ways as well, such as by the dominant archetypes. The fullest myths for him are personal ones, fitting most snugly the unique contour of each person's unconscious. Far from losing the individual in the group, Jung favors the individual, as Ellwood himself stresses. Primitive mentality is that of the herd.

I would characterize Jung's position on myth as romantic but not reactionary. Myth for romantic Jung is not merely primitive, is not about the physical word, and is not superseded by science. Moderns as well as primitives have and maybe must have myths: "Has mankind ever really got away from myths? . . . [I]f all the world's traditions were cut off at a single blow, the whole of mythology . . . would start all over again with the next generation" (Jung: 25; see also Segal 1998: 32–34 and chap. 8). Myth is a fount of wisdom. But the key to interpreting myth is twentieth-century psychology. Myth and modernity are thus allies, not antagonists.

When, in both his review essay and his book, Ellwood turns to Eliade, he considers the theorist at least as much as the theory. Unlike Jung, Eliade has frequently been charged with trucking not merely with anti-Semitic sentiments but with an anti-Semitic movement. Typically, Ellwood, while ever balanced, tends to be charitable. But what of the theory? Eliade fits Ellwood's reactionary romanticism more readily than Jung. Eliade vaunts primitives over moderns and the sacred past over the profane present. Like a magic carpet, myth functions to carry one back to primordial time and thereby to the gods. Myth is universal and indispensable. Primitives are superior to moderns, for they recognize their need for myth. Whereas the myths of primitives are public and conscious, those of moderns are private, camouflaged, and even degenerate: "In short, the majority of men 'without religion' still hold to pseudo religions and degenerated mythologies" (Eliade: 209). Unlike Jung, Eliade favors group myths over individual ones.

Like Jung, Eliade bemoans the one-sided character of moderns and, also like Jung, attributes that one-sidedness to the rise of science and the demise of religion. But Eliade is more extreme. Whereas Jung seeks to reconcile myth with modernity, Eliade seeks to topple modernity in the name of myth. Whereas Jung can reconcile myth with modernity because myth, read symbolically, is not about the outer world and so is not in conflict with science, Eliade cannot reconcile myth with modernity because he reads myth literally. Instead, he argues for the continuing presence of myth amid modernity and as more than a Tylolean relic or "survival." But myth and modernity remain at odds. If the sacred still exists in the modern profane, it does so paradoxically and defiantly. In his book Ellwood boldly

suggests that Eliade actually embraces modernity in celebrating new manifestations of the sacred (see 1999: 98, 119–120). But surely even those manifestations still exist paradoxically within modernity. Furthermore, Eliade's relentless opposition to the scientific study of religion evinces a rejection of modernity antithetical to Jung's participation in it. In short, Eliade is more reactionary for me than for Ellwood. Eliade's position is more dualistic and therefore more gnostic-like than Jung's, but in finding the sacred imbedded in the profane and not merely trapped in it, Eliade's dualism is less radical than the gnostic variety.

What of the politics of myth? Like Jung, Eliade clearly categorizes mythologies by nations, but also like Jung he characterizes myths in other ways as well, such as by religions. For Eliade, as for Malinowski, myth traces back the origin of present-day social phenomena and in that sense bolsters them. Myth thus brings the sacred forward to the present. But surely myth also takes one out of the present and back to the past. Eliade thus interprets political hopes for future paradise, including that of staunchly atheistic Marxism, as really a hoped-for return to the prepolitical, prelapsarian past (see 206–207).

When, in his book, Ellwood turns to Campbell, he again accords at least as much attention to the theorist as to the theory. In his review essay he notes that, despite my having documented elsewhere Campbell's anti-Semitism (see Segal 1992a), in my book I sidestep the issue. I do so because, despite Ellwood's efforts, I think it hard to tie Campbell's or other theorists' political positions to their positions on myth. In my book on Campbell (see Segal 1997) I trace Campbell's changing assessments of peoples. Over the course of his writings he variously touts the East over the West, the West over the East, hunters over farmers, farmers over hunters, primitives over moderns, and moderns over primitives. He takes no consistent line.

But what of Campbell's theory? For all his exasperatingly fluctuating views of the origin and function of myth (see Segal 1997: chaps. 10–11), he consistently maintains that all myth preaches a world-affirming rather than world-rejecting message. In *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* the protagonist, having ventured forth to a strange, divine world, returns home to discover that the divine world had been there all along, if only one had had the eyes to see it. The sacred does not merely exist dialectically in the profane, as for Eliade, let alone lie trapped in the profane, as for gnosticism. The sacred *is* the profane (see Campbell: 217). Campbell espouses what W. T. Stace calls "extrovertive" mysticism. Campbell's own extrovertive quest for the sacred took the form not of meditation but of running and, later, swimming.

Whereas both Jung and Eliade seek to revive myth in the wake of the rise of science and the fall of religion, Campbell pits myth against reli-

gion—sometimes western religions, sometimes all religions. The fall of religion spells the salvation of myth. Whereas for Jung and Eliade moderns must scamper to create new myths, for Campbell myths get created almost spontaneously. Science itself spurs the creation of myths. Whereas for Jung modern psychology provides the grid for understanding myth, for Campbell primitives themselves have been psychologists. Only benighted moderns need Jung to decipher myth (see Campbell: vii). In these ways Campbell is even more antimodern than Jung or Eliade.

Seemingly, myth for Campbell contains a blatantly political message. For the hero, having set off for some personal reason, agrees to return from the divine world only for the sake of the community. But then Campbell's Jungian-like psychologizing of myths turns the heroic quest into a solipsistic quest for self-knowledge. The community disappears. The extrovertive Campbell does not turn away from the outer world in any gnostic-like manner, but the goal is personal, not collective.

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